

One last dance in New York

With the Grand Slam season drawing to a close, here are the players who are best placed to make their mark at the **US Open.**

Paul Fein



FOR MORE
STORIES

WOMEN

Yogi Berra, the inimitable baseball sage, once said, "It's tough to make predictions, especially about the future." This has never rung truer in women's tennis. Parity has prevailed this year with three different Grand Slam champions — Elena Rybakina and first-time winners Mirra Andrejeva and Linda Noskova. They vanquished three other Slam finalists — Aryna Sabalenka, shock qualifier Maja Chwalinska and Karolina Muchova. If you like surprises, you should get plenty more at the last Major of 2026. Will the US Open produce yet another first-time Slam champion? Or will a veteran star restore order on the courts? And will your favourite player flourish or flounder? Let's find out who will best handle inspired opponents, the oppressive New York heat and humidity, and the raucous spectators. In reverse order, with an additional bonus selection, here are my picks.

"Alex Eala has an X factor to make her opponent play worse. This is an art form in an era of sheer power," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Mark Petchey. Eala displayed finesse, power, grit and smart tactics when she captured the Mubadala DC Open in early August, becoming the first Filipina to win a WTA title. A crowd favourite wherever she plays, Eala used their energy to conquer a brutal draw, beating Olympic gold medallist Zheng Qinwen, Leylah Fernandez, No. 10-ranked Elina Svitolina, four-time Major champion Naomi Osaka, and No. 3 Jessica Pegula. "Credit Eala for playing fearless, bold tennis," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Alison Riske-Amritraj, after Eala grabbed the last eight games to upset Pegula in a riveting 4-6, 6-4, 6-0 final.

Earlier this season, the 5ft 9in left-hander whipped Coco Gauff at Indian Wells, No. 2 Rybakina and Svitolina in Berlin, and Iga Swiatek at Wimbledon. The weak links in Eala's game are her first serve, which averages only 90 mph, and an attackable second serve, averaging a meek 74 mph — 12 mph below the tour average. Eala mania can take her only so far.

ALEXANDRA EALA

No. 20



Prediction: Quarterfinals